OEKO-TEX® Association

General Manager Meeting

24th – 25th October 2024, Alcoy

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1 Overview

Meeting subject	General Manager Meeting
Date & Time	24. – 25.10.2024, Alcoy
Participants live	Aitex: Vicente Blanes Julia (VB), Isabel Soriano Sarrió (IS), Consuelo Carbonell (CC) Centexbel: Jan Laperre (JL) Centrocot: Dr. Grazia Cerini (GC) Citeve: Braz Costa (BC) DTI: Johnny Rodam (JR) FILK: Prof. Dr. Haiko Schulz (HS) Hohenstein: Prof. Dr. Stefan Mecheels (SM), Dr. Stefan Droste (SDr) Innovatext: Dr. Lívia Kokas Palicska (LK) Mirtec: Athanasios Stamou (ASt), Kelly Stathopoulou (KS) Nissenken: Toshiaki Yamazaki (TY) OETI: Robert Löcker (RL) RISE: Lene Jul Östblom (LÖ) Shirley: Stephen Donnelly (SDo) TESTEX: Rainer Roten (RR), Dr. Jean-Pierre Haug (JH), Matz Bachmann (MB) OEKO-TEX®: Dr. Alfred J. Beerli (AB), Inga Bleyer (IB), Carolin Franitza (CF), Elisa Rimmele (ER), Jonathan Wehrli (JW)
Participants online	IFTH: Clarisse Reille (CR) OEKO-TEX®: Fanny Racine (FR), Annika Sauerhöfer (ASa), Anna Hänsli (AH)
Absentees	DTNW: Prof. Dr. Jochen Gutmann IFTH: Clarisse Reille Lukasiewicz-LIT: Dr. Ing. Renata Żyłła STFI: Dr. Heike Illing-Günther Umweltlabor ACB: Melanie Dieckmann
Author	OEKO-TEX®: Inga Bleyer (IB), Carolin Franitza (CF), Elisa Rimmele (ER), Jonathan Wehrli (JW)

2 Welcome & General Updates

Dr Alfred Beerli, new CEO of the OEKO-TEX® association since July 2024 and chairperson of the General Manager Meeting, officially welcomes all people present and gives a note of thanks to Vicente Blanes from Aitex for inviting us into the new Aitex building and for the organisation of the 2024 OEKO-TEX® General Manager meeting. He thanked all members of the OEKO-TEX® association for the good cooperation and fruitful discussions of the past year.

After the welcome Dr. Alfred J. Beerli took the opportunity to introduce himself. He shared his career path, work experience, professional learnings and his accomplishments in the textile and IT area with the group.

He briefly shared his vison for the future of OEKO-TEX®:

- Digitalisation and focus on the technical and go to market development of OEKO-TEX® MADE IN GREEN
- Product innovation and increasing investments into Quality Management
- A more holistic approach for our standards and a vision for sustainability extends beyond product testing

As the new CEO, Dr. Alfred J. Beerli is committed to fostering loyalty, maintaining transparency and encouraging open communication. By working together with the same high standards and building trust, he aims to achieve the shared goals of the OEKO-TEX® association effectively.

Alfred Beerli is looking forward getting to know all the General Managers and their respective institutes better over the two -days meeting.

He looks forward learning more about the individual challenges of the institutes and exploring opportunities for collaboration and growth.

The meeting was opened, 24th October 9:00am.

3 Finances

In the financial year 2023/2024 the costs have been reduced by 2.4 million, mainly driven by costs savings in IT. Due to this savings, a repayment to the institute will be done.
According to the tax rules and agreement with Zurich City, we have a reimbursement for 2023 / 2024 to all institutes.

OEKO-TEX® is considering significant investments in IT infrastructure and further developments to shape the future of the association. It may be necessary for OEKO-TEX® to request an investment from the association.

AB has asked to refrain from spending the reimbursed funds and instead reserve them for OEKO-TEX® proposals on new developments, particularly regarding IT systems and IT organisation.

JL, Centexbel: What are the advantages of the current tax system

RR, Testex: The tax agreement is a good agreement and results in lower taxes for OEKO-TEX®. Going forward the tax system might be in question.

At the end of the financial slides AB emphasized the importance not to spend the 1.4m reimbursement. It is a critical contribution into the development of the OEKO-TEX® IT infrastructure. In the future there might be the need to increase the licence fees, due to higher fix costs of OEKO-TEX®.

VB, Aitex: Where did we spend the 1.3 mio Marketing?

IB, OKEO-TEX®: Approx. 60% are spend for maintaining global marketing and communication, graphics and marketing assets for customers globally, website development maintenance, social media B2B and B2C, fairs like Heimtextil. Additional budget is spent on paid media in focus countries, as China, DACH region, UK and US.

SDr, Hohenstein: Is thankful for the financial turnaround in 2023/2024 and emphasizes the importance of being resourceful regarding the costs of OEKO-TEX® office.

Please see the financial presentation for more details.

4 Organisation

OEKO-TEX® has 25 employees as of October 2024. The OEKO-TEX® team structure is under discussion and reorganisation is needed to be more efficient.

5 Minutes: General Manager Meeting 2023

No comments were made concerning the minutes of last year´s General Manager Meeting in Budapest (25th – 27th October 2023) and therefore they are accepted as being sent out.

6 Portfolio Statistics

The last business year was a successful year for OEKO-TEX®. MADE IN GREEN grew strongest by 52% which is a great step for OEKO-TEX®, although the actual number of labels is low in comparison to STANDARD 100.

Further details can be found in the presentation.

- GC, Centrocot: Is asking for the Freemium Model of the Impact Calculator
    - AB, OEKO-TEX®: Agreed, it could be an additional tool and opportunity for OEKO-TEX®.

- SDr, Hohenstein: It would be great to know the STANDARD 100 numbers that actually involve testing.
    - IB & ER, OEKO-TEX®: Agreed, but with the current database, statistics are a big challenge for OEKO-TEX®. Unfortunately, OEKO-TEX® is not able to pull the requested numbers in the actual IT set up.

7 General Discussions

More general and various points were brought up in lively discussions during the meeting:

Quality and Fairplay:

- RR, Testex: For OEKO-TEX® quality is key so we urgently need to strengthen our internal quality control. A strong and reliable internal quality system is needed.
  Please see comments on page 21 (8.13) and page 29ff.
-

IT & Digitalisation:

- BC, Citeve: A global streamlined system and information technology is needed. We need to have a clear idea and plan what IT means for our business. OEKO-TEX® sells data and information, as a core business.
  - AB: We see two options to develop / update the OEKO-TEX® IT system:
    1. Copy the system as it is now
    2. Reengineering of a new system

    A commitment is needed from the OEKO-TEX® association to reduce the scope of the IT implementation and develop a framework first. Ich würde den gelben Teil rausnehmen.

Independency of OEKO-TEX® and ISO 17065

- How to go further with ISO 17065: We agreed that we will not open our service to other testing institutes. Discussions about the setup of the OEKO-TEX® association for independence requirements according to the EU-ECGT legislation are taking place and the need to drive this discussion forward is urgent.
  In the virtual GMM in 2022 the option of involving an external consulting company (law firm) was discussed. Next steps, need to be taken fast due to the pressure from EU regulations.
  - JL, Centexbel: How to mitigate the risks and have a plan?
  - CF, OEKO-TEX®: Agrees, need to have a risk analysis in place.

DPP

- JR, DTI: What do we do as an association with DPP?
  - AB, OEKO-TEX®: We are in contact with various organisations. There is a lot of uncertainty in the industry and clear next steps for the industry are not known by now.
  - JR, DTI: We need to offer a solution, assure our customers and have a harmonised approach as association to answering customer questions.
  - JH, Testex: There will not be one solution. We need to be ready, through APIs to deliver the needed information to DPP providers. Providers are interested to collect and gather the information.

- CF, OEKO-TEX®: There was not a standstill, OEKO-TEX® is very familiar with the situation and has built a good network with different stakeholder. It is unclear how the final situation will look and in order to build a task force, additional capacities at OEKO-TEX® are necessary.
- AB, OEKO-TEX®: We will deliver an official OEKO-TEX® statement to all institutes. The message should be: We are following the development very intensively and are prepared to fulfil the requirement with the respective data. We are active, we are prepared, and we are in contact with the relevant stakeholder. We have been in contact with several big customers.
- JL, Centexbel: At the moment it is even very unclear which product group will be affected.
- GC, Centrocot: We are collaborating on an EU project that aims to integrate OEKO-TEX® data through an API, but no final answer yet.
- JL, Centexbel: EURATEX will likely play a significant role in the final decision, making it essential to stay informed about their developments.
- CF, OEKO-TEX®: We are aware. The contact with EURATEX is as a next step on our agenda. We will keep you posted.

8 Reports of the Institutes

(Alphabetical order)

8.1 AITEX

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation.

General information:

- Comparison AFIRM and OEKO-TEX®: AFIRM is important for many brands and there are discrepancies to our standards.
- JW, OEKO-TEX®: We have done this comparison already and are aware of the differences. We are doing the same for bluesign and are looking to align. Most of the time we are stricter. Will be discussed during the next RSL/MRSL-Meeting.
- VB, Aitex: Application form must be digitalised – support of the group
- VB, Aitex: Quality working group and control of fair play - support of the group
- VB, Aitex: DPP is a very important topic. Proposal to establish a working group with 3 main criteria: to protect business, to know what will happen in 2027, to make it easy for the customer

8.2 Centexbel

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation.

Acquisition of VUTCH:

What is the reason behind it?

- Financing for research activities
- Supporting the activities and tasks of Centexbel employees in Gent with qualified staff

Suggestions, questions, comments:

The status with Vutch in the OEKO-TEX® association might change. JL, Centexbel, will inform actively about upcoming changes. As of now, Vutch will remain a full member of the OEKO-TEX® association.

8.3 CENTROCOT

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- ZDHC is very important in Italy and for Centrocot
- Centrocot is a ZDHC solution provider for Clear Stream
- Please see the presentation on ZDHC and BHive activities
- Best practice from MultiLab was shared: Please see the presentation for details
- Celebrating 30 years of Centrocot and OEKO-TEX® at the ZDHC roadshow. The attendance was very good and generate good media coverage.
- RESPONSIBLE BUSINESS is an important topic and certification in Italy. Centrocot needs support from OEKO-TEX® with an important potential customer.
- Centrocot is pushing the LEATHER STANDARD

Future Opportunities:

- GC, Centrocot: Requests more general trainings regarding guidebooks and implementation of all OEKO-TEX® standards for institutes from OEKO-TEX®
- GC raises the concern that the OEKO-TEX® ORGANIC COTTON certification is cannibalizing the relationships of Centrocot to GOTS. This will lead to less testing and STANDARD 100 certifications for Centrocot.
    - SDr, Hohenstein: The launch of the ORGANIC COTTON launch is an important step for OEKO-TEX®, especially for learnings about traceability. Hohenstein is investing into the development to drive market adaptation.
- SDo, Shirley: Agrees, we need to put power and resources behind OEKO-TEX® ORGANIC COTTON to make it a success story.

8.4 Citeve

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- Citeve has a new building – up 6,000sm
- Growth rate of R&D activities increased to 40%
- Number of employees is growing – finding qualified staff is still difficult

Challenges:

- DPP is very important for the OEKO-TEX® association: How can OEKO-TEX® participate in DPP? The Association needs to come back with a plan. It is crucial to be ahead of competitors.
- ISO 17065 accreditation: Next steps: Looking into how OEKO-TEX® will be set up in the future, looking into already agreed and upcoming EU legislations
- Automation and digitalisation of the certification process –simplify the life of our customers.

Opportunities:

- IT needs to be the driving force – more focus on IT
- More B2C communication is needed – build an OEKO-TEX® community to drive a bigger brand awareness
- MADE IN GREEN – clear demand for a traceability tool in the market
- DPP: IT support to DPP
- Big opportunity: Setting up the dedicated pricing system for OEKO-TEX® services that are currently for free

Suggestions, questions, comments:

- Time between adoption of new substances and established of the method needs to be prolonged.

GC, Centrocot VB, Aitex: Centrocot and Aitex have accredited the OEKO-TEX® methods according to ISO 17025
JPH, Testex: The accreditation method varies by country.
ER, OEKO-TEX®: The method working group is looking to define certain key methods which should be included into the ISO 17025 certification in the future. It is well understood that this is a cost and time factor.

8.5 DTI

DANISH TECHNOLOGICAL INSTITUTE

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- DTI reports a big increase in STANDARD 100 certificates with recycled content
- DTI is very concerned about the amount of unauthorized marketing – companies without certificate claim to have a certificate, usually does not lead to a certificate
    - LÖ, RISE: Observe the same issue, very often it is ingredient labelling
    - GC, Centrocot: If Centrocot contacts customers that do false labelling, it usually leads to a certificate.
    - SDO, Shirley: How does DTI find out?
    - JR, DTI: A lot of manual work is involved. Someone checks the internet, and they then contact the companies.
    - AB, OEKO-TEX®: We see an increase in these cases. Currently there are 86 open cases with lawyers. The OEKO-TEX® learning is, that pressure and fining does not always help. A process should be established.
    - SDr, Hohenstein: If the company is in Denmark, then there should be a legal way to get in contact with them. Be forceful, copy right infringement and fining is working. It is a tough and costly conflict.

8.6 FILK

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- EUDR is postponed: more requests from EUDR needs to be included in the LEATHER STANDARD in the next year
- PFAS is not a huge problem in the leather industry.
- Presentation of the results of the survey done by ILM – please see the presentation for details
- Positive signs: Strong competition with LWG but increasing influence of OEKO-TEX® in the leather sector.
    - HS, FILK: How can we manage a positive agreement with the LWG?
- CSCB is gaining more market share – please see insight from the ILM survey
- JH, Testex: What is the impact on the Leather industry regarding EUDR – what is affected, especially production in Europe?
    - HS, FILK: Unclear how it will be affecting other hides like sheep and goat. At the moment, only cows are affected.

8.7 HOHENSTEIN

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- John Frazier will retire by end of November 2024
- Prof. Mecheels will move into the family board in 2025
- Martin Cieslik will join the board of Hohenstein group
- Bangladesh is still a challenge – violence against police and the situation is not stable.
- ZDHC partnership is a challenge and a question. ZDHC have a lot more capacities to push the agendas.
- OEKO-TEX® still has strong market position, but we need to be ready for what is coming.

ORGANIC COTTON / Recycling

- ORGANIC COTTON is growing well and Hohenstein stands behind the topic.
- GOTS is our main competitor in the organic cotton market and is strong in marketing and spinning the message
- The certificates demand is growing
- Traceability is key (mass balance tracing) – OEKO-TEX® needs to invest in IT, if the OEKO-TEX® ORGANIC COTTON certification is to remain / grow in the market

What type of OEKO-TEX® do we want to be? Integrity, Reliability, Comparability

But:

- Competition of institutes leads to costumer confusion and may damage quality and reputation.
- Increase of retest fails in RSL programs.

SDr, Hohenstein: A robust communication system regarding quality issues needs to be established among all institutes, particularly when dealing with unreliable suppliers.

OEKO-TEX® will return with a proposal for a solution on how to establish an effective communication system for improved coordination among institute.

8.8 IFTH

The presentation was done online.

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- CR, ifth: Request to allow organic STANDARD 100 sister certificates until 2026 for brands
    - AB, OEKO-TEX®: OEKO-TEX® will be get back to IFTH and the group if further discussion is needed.

8.9 INNOVATEXT

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- The inflation is still high in Hungary but situation is improving
- 2 new STeP auditor, training is still challenging.
- LK, Innovatext: Training for STeP auditors should be held in Europe as well, not only in Middle East and Asia.
- Focus on digital marketing in the future.

Challenges:

- How to improve LEATHER STANDARD?
  The prices for LEATHER STANDARD are too high for the Hungarian market.

8.10 Lukasiewicz-LIT

No presentation for the financial year 2023/2024 was shared by Lukasiewicz.

8.11 Mirtec

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- See presentation

8.12 Nissenken

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- See presentation

Suggestions, questions, comments:

- TY, Nissenken: Request to ensure that certificates cannot be easily faked.

8.13 OETI

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information and challenges:

- Competitive and quality issues have been experienced – pricing offer too low according to Guidebook.
    - RL, OETI: Request OEKO-TEX® to build up a strong quality management department. We need to build up an organization to control and stop counter offers within the association.
    - JL, Centexbel: Training on how to apply the guidebook before the punishment. Proposal: Do training with all institutes so the guidebook will be read by all institutes the same way.
    - BC, Citeve: Fairplay is not working well within the OEKO-TEX® Association. On top of training some tools need to be developed to empower our technicians.
    - JL, Centexbel: Use the matrix, but it is not mandatory.
    - VB, Aitex: Some points of the guidebook should be written more clearly, avoid room for interpretation or options.
    - GC, Centrocot: Pricing is a sensible topic in Italy. What about the small companies? The STeP pricing and hour system is not working for small companies. ZDHC is less expensive, so small companies are choosing Roadmap to Zero over STeP.
    - SDr, Hohenstein: Strongly supports a position where these issues are taking up. OEKO-TEX® should have the authority to expose a certain fee, but also needs to establish and supports more training.

  Consultancies that undergo the prices are a global issue. We need a position and resources at OEKO-TEX®, where these issues can be reported to.

    - SDo: Do we need a register with all official auditors for OEKO-TEX® so there are identified?
- RL, OETI: Banning of an auditor – this would require more audits of OEKO-TEX® in specific countries.
- RL, OETI: Proposal: Have an OEKO-TEX® auditor placed in the Asian market
- RL: OETI: The 3 years auditing cycle is not enough

8.14 RISE

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- Short introduction to general set up of RISE
- Digital Product Passport is driving business in the Nordic countries
- Circularity and sustainability are very important to Nordic consumers.

8.15 SHIRLEY

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- Engaging with brands through OEKO-TEX® roadshows is working well
- First STeP customer in Africa in 2024
- Big increase of MADE IN GREEN but needs more development and a user friendly interface
- RESPONSIBLE BUSINESS is not addressing the promotional and commercial market needs, but only the regulatory market. Do we miss an ESG opportunity?

Challenges:

- RESPONSIBLE BUSINESS: Brands in the UK are interested in ESG and are engaged with BCorp although BCorp costs more than £10,000.
- Problem with the taxations in India.

  SDo is happy to share the experience with other institutes if the taxation agency approaches other institutes.

8.16 TESTEX

TESTEX®

OEKO-TEX® numbers: please refer to the presentation

General information:

- Testex group with approx. 400 employees. An organizational change in the eastern part of the group is in progress. New equipment for the laboratory and investment in the future are in progress as well.
- Others see presentation

9 Stakeholder Engagement

Main presentation: see slides 18 to 25

Slide 22: OECD was happy with our result, but OEKO-TEX® is not too happy with it. The level approach is what was criticised the most.

- CF, OEKO-TEX®: We are lacking capacities which are needed to be up to date with the massive changes in the market
- SDr, Hohenstein: Feedback from different stakeholders that Carolin is doing a great job representing our standards and engaging with different stakeholders.
- JPH, Testex: Are the OECD guidelines also applicable to other industries?
    - CF, OEKO-TEX®: Yes, they are applicable to other industries
    - JPH, Testex: The textile supply chains are very complex which is a big challenge. The level approach was a way to allow progress and simply it.
    - CF, OEKO-TEX®: With the CSDDD the game will change.
    - JH, Testex: Unsure how the task of implementing will be possible
    - SDo, Shirley: How it will be enforced is the big questions.

10 Technical Updates for 2025

Main presentation: see slides 41 - 60

In the following only the results are documented.

Most proposals accepted before the meeting vis a forms survey.

10.1 RSL / MRSL

- Bisphenols - Accepted
- Bis-(α,α-dimethylbenzyl)-peroxide – looking for method but will already implement - Accepted
- Pesticides - Accepted
    - JPH, Testex: expanded the list without raising prices
- Methylisothiazolinone – we take it off the list - Accepted

10.2 PFAS

- Intentional use of fluorinated non-PFAS substances – Not accepted. There will not be any exceptions
    - SDr, Hohenstein: prefers not to have an exception and introduce exception if there are legally introduced. Rather be safe than sorry from a legal perspective
    - JPH, Testex: Agrees with SDr, maybe the chemical industry will provide precedence

10.3 STANDARD 100

- Fragrances – Not accepted. Fragrances to be completely banned
    - SDr, Hohenstein: Can you summarize the stakeholder consultation?
- CF, OEKO-TEX®: 159 participants, including relevant stakeholders such as Dystar, Archroma, Procter & Gamble, ITC, bluesign, GIZ.
    - KS, Mirtex: What is the definition of fragrance? Are masking agents part of fragrance?
        - FR, OEKO-TEX®: Masking products were not considered in the proposal

- Microencapsulated products – Not accepted, microencapsulated products may still be used in STANDARD 100
    - SDr, Hohenstein: Do not ban the way it is delivered (encapsulation) but the chemical which are released

- Microplastic - Accepted
    - SDr, Hohenstein: We tested this method, but tape must be specified

- FR, OEKO-TEX®: A complete method including time, pressure and tape will be established by the Method Working Group, important that the tape is available in all countries including Japan.
    - Currently only for glitter!
    - JPH, Testex: Can we use it to collect data on microplastic?
- SDr, Hohenstein: Let's collect microplastic results, but not share them with customers yet.

- Expansion of PFAS exception list for PPE – Accepted

- Known chemical list by INDITEX for testing reduction – Accepted

10.4 ECO PASSPORT

- Commodity chemicals - Accepted

11 Quality Management

11.1 Control Test

Main presentation: see slides 61 - 90

The presented information was well received and no comments or questions were raised.

11.2 Now what / Fair play

A strategic approach to the discussed failures is lacking

Fair play Proposal - Accepted

- We go for a minimum following the guidebook
- We should think about grievance / learning → document these cases
- Ultimate decision should come from OEKO-TEX® to set the fine and institutes must all abide
- This is a growing issue → we must develop tools so that people can be more effective and we limit the non-intentional cases
- Ethics are different in different cultures so it should be made sure that the rules are known by all
- Please don't call it punishment
- OEKO-TEX® needs to check the testing plan, not the prices set by the institute
- If rules are unclear, they must be improved first before an institute will be fined
- Clear rules and guidelines will be set in place and checked for legal compliance
- A fine was agreed by the General Managers for non-compliance with pricing guidelines from the guidebook. The fine will be 3 times the difference to the guidebook and to be paid to the OEKO-TEX Service GmbH

Transfer Fee proposal: Accepted

- A transfer fee was discussed to be paid by the institute to disincentivize all customer changes between institutes.

  Proposal: Fine the institute if the 14 day transfer is not honoured - Accepted

  - Make the rules clear, what will happen when this rule is broken and how the institute is reprimanded.
  - Fine: 3-Times the certificate fee
  - When in doubt then for the institute
  - Fine to be paid to the OEKO-TEX Service GmbH
  - The rule will be implemented after a legal check

RR, Testex: Testex has constructed a test matrix that can be shared with the OEKO-TEX® association. Next steps: discuss price and licensing of this list. It will be demonstrated and tested.

11.3 Organic Cotton

Proposal: Addition of ORGANIC COTTON to control testing - Accepted

11.4 Round Robin Tests

Presentation given and well received.

Incognito Application: keep the same number as the virtual applications

Taken out of RRT and have it as a separate topic

12 On-Site Visit/Audit Management

Main presentation: see slides 90 - 108

The presented information was well received.

Bangladesh could be added to the list of Self-Assessment because it is unsafe.

Proposal: Strengthening On-Site Visits - Accepted

- Who will do the unannounced audits → the linked institute
- Consequences must be harsh
- Pricing must be discussed
- The finer points will be worked out and brought to everyone

13 ZDHC Update & Discussion

Main presentation: see slides 26 – 38

The presented information was well received.

- GC, Centrocot: Could OEKO-TEX® share the results of the pilot project within the OEKO-TEX® STeP x ZDHC Supplier to Zero cooperation.
    - CF, OEKO-TEX®: OEKO-TEX® will share the results.

Discussion: What is most important to you in the collaboration with ZDHC? Which topics would you like us to engage with ZDHC on?

- GC, Centrocot: The organisation within ZDHC is currently not clear regarding Aspirational Level. We do not have enough information regarding this topic.
- SDr, Hohenstein: Despite the challenges in cooperation, ZDHC's strong market presence makes it difficult to disengage. Identifying actionable insights from exchanges with ZDHC has been challenging. To maintain ECO PASSPORT's success, we should adopt a balanced approach and avoid pushing too hard. In the short term, it would be beneficial to focus on more visible collaborations and shift from strategic discussions with Frank Michel to operational-level exchanges. Involve Szilard Szarvas, our new team member, in developing cooperation plans. In the medium to long term, we may gain a stronger position as OEKO-TEX®'s relevance to their business increases.
    - JW, OEKO-TEX®: Could approach their new Chief Program Officer Francesco Piana.
- JPH, Testex: Biggest value of ZDHC is their close relationship with brands. OEKO-TEX® should be more visible within their network.
- RR, Testex: ZDHC is interested in data exchange. A relationship map could support the strategic discussion. We could share our blacklists to be more aware of fraudulent activities.

14 Project updates

14.1 MADE IN GREEN Updates

Main presentation: see slides 123 – 144

The presented information was well received.

- SDo, Shirley: The roadmap direction is on target, with a valuable connection to DPP development. IT infrastructure is essential as a foundation for this progress. Shirley could support by organizing a brand-focused event to gather input for advancing the MADE IN GREEN development.
- MB, Testex: Agrees with SDo. For the carbon and water footprint tool, exploring external solutions and potential partnerships may offer efficient pathways.
- JPH, Testex: Agrees with both SDo and MB, emphasizing the importance of supply chain traceability, especially upstream. As GOTS adopts an upstream traceability model, it could be seen as a straightforward option also for OEKO-TEX®.
    - AS, OEKO-TEX®: We should not limit our service to one technology. Both, upstream and downstream traceability would be important.
    - The GMs agree with AS.

Suggestion to developing a resource allocation plan for the MADE IN GREEN development.

The GMs support further allocation of resources for this project.

15 Marketing & Communication

Main presentation: see slides 145 – 172

The presented information was well received.

- IB, OEKO-TEX®: What are your thoughts on planning an internal summit?
  - SDr, Hohenstein & SDo, Shirley: While the potential value is high, the time and cost required are significant.

    The interested to further investigate the potential of an external OEKO-TEX® customer summit was expressed through GM's.

- IB, OEKO-TEX®: What are your thoughts on conducting a B2B customer survey?
  - SDr, Hohenstein & RL, OETI: Institutes already conduct customer surveys regularly and could share relevant findings (e.g. lead times) with the OEKO-TEX® team. However, responsibility and engagement should remain with the institutes so that staff in direct contact with customers can learn and improve services effectively.
  - JL, Centexbel: Our team hasn't gained significant insights from past customer surveys. Efforts might be too high.
  - IB, OEKO-TEX®: Without a direct connection to customers, the Marketing team currently has limited exposure to the market.
  - JPH, Testex: The Marketing team could suggest topics of interest for OEKO-TEX® to be included in the institutes' customer surveys.
  - SDr, Hohenstein: Invites the Marketing team to participate in customer meetings to gain more direct insights. Also sees value in an external summit to enhance engagement.

- IB, OEKO-TEX®: What are your thoughts on conducting an end consumer survey?
  - SDo, Shirley: It would be valuable to assess OEKO-TEX® brand awareness as a baseline before any awareness-building efforts.

- IB, OEKO-TEX®: What are your thoughts on investing efforts for a revision of our claim "Inspiring Confidence"?
  - BC, Citeve & KS, Mirtec: Legal aspects, particularly around emerging green claims, should be carefully considered. It is a good idea to explore this topic further.
  - The GMs agree to follow up with additional investigations.

- IB, OEKO-TEX®: What do you expect from OEKO-TEX® Marketing?
  - BC, Citeve: Support efforts to increase the number of certificates.
  - SM, Hohenstein: How extensively does OEKO-TEX® use testimonials?
    - IB, OEKO-TEX®: We already share success stories and would like to expand this, but need support from the institutes to gather more stories.
  - VB, Aitex: It's important to have a clear, singular message for customers, with a primary focus on MADE IN GREEN.
  - SDr, Hohenstein: Greater brand recognition among end consumers would facilitate conversations with brands.

16 Institute`s Expectations of OEKO-TEX® Secretariat Zurich

The General Managers have no further expectations.

17 Various

The next General Manager meeting will be held on the 30th - 31st October 2024 in Denmark.

AB thanks the General Managers for the fruitful discussions and closes the meeting.

The meeting was closed, 25th October 4:30 pm.